

Week 8 – WordPress: Developing Custom Themes

Learning Activities & Resources

1. Finished the LearnJCU weekly lecture video.
2. Studied the LinkedIn Learning courses *WordPress: Building Progressive Themes with WP Rig* and *WordPress Developer Tips: DRY Development*.
3. Formulated a learning hypothesis that “using visual diagrams during coding studies will significantly improve my understanding compared to reading text-only explanations.”
4. Conducted a self-test by incorporating hand-drawn flowcharts and architecture diagrams into my study sessions.
5. Compared my comprehension before and after using diagrams through short quizzes and code walkthroughs.
6. Gathered external input from classmates—six reported strong benefits using diagrams, two reported moderate improvements, and one said diagrams made little difference.
7. Participated in a group meeting for the Baizonn Learning Centre project to refine our development strategy and assign theme development tasks.
8. Completed the setup of our starter theme and began implementing customisations for layout, navigation, and content structure.

Estimated Hours

20 hours

Content Insights

This week's work on WordPress custom theme development offered valuable insights into building fast, accessible, and maintainable themes. The WP Rig workflow introduced in the LinkedIn Learning course emphasised **performance-first development**, automated build processes, and modern front-end standards. I learned how tools like ESLint, Sass, and build optimisers can significantly improve code quality while reducing manual effort.

The DRY (Don't Repeat Yourself) principles highlighted the importance of reusability across template parts, functions, and styles. Structuring the theme with modular components—such as separate template partials for headers, footers, and loops—helps maintain consistency and makes future updates more efficient.

For our Baizonn Learning Centre project, choosing a starter theme allowed the team to move into a more productive phase. Uploading client materials and organising them within the WordPress environment provided clarity on the site's content structure. This step sets the foundation for customising the theme to reflect the client's branding and functional requirements.

Career / Employability / Learning Insights

My learning experiment this week focused on whether **visual diagrams** can improve understanding during coding studies. After integrating diagrams into my workflow and comparing quiz results, I noticed better recall of theme structure, template hierarchy, and file relationships. The findings—supported by feedback from classmates—suggest that visual learning tools are particularly useful when understanding how theme components interact. This experiment reinforced the importance of selecting study techniques that match both personal learning style and the complexity of the material.

Our group meeting played an important role in building collaboration and leadership skills. Discussing responsibilities and development tasks helped strengthen team communication and established a clearer workflow. With the starter theme selected, we now have a strong technical direction to guide our next development steps.

From a career perspective, the ability to develop custom WordPress themes is a practical and in-demand skill in web development. Modern businesses rely heavily on performance, accessibility, and scalability—areas that WP Rig and DRY principles specifically target. Gaining experience with these tools and methodologies helps build a portfolio that stands out in a competitive job market.

Working on the Baizonn Learning Centre project continues to develop real-world problem-solving, client communication, and professional

development workflows—all of which are essential for success in future full-stack or front-end development roles.